

**WORKSHOP TO FINALISE CURRICULUM-BASED ACCREDITATION CRITERIA FOR
UNDERGRADUATE PHARMACY TRAINING PROGRAMMES IN THE ECOWAS
REGION**

Organised by:

The West African Health Organisation (WAHO)

Venue: Bobo Dioulasso, Burkina Faso

Date: November 19–20, 2013

By:

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1.0 PREAMBLE

From February 23 to 25, 2011, Registrars from some ECOWAS countries and Deans of Faculties of Pharmacy met in Cotonou, Benin Republic, under the auspices of WAHO, to brainstorm on the *“Draft Consensus Document for Pharmacists’ Training in the ECOWAS Region.”*

A follow-up meeting was held in the same Cotonou from July 30 to August 1, 2012, again under the auspices of WAHO, for a *“Workshop to Develop Criteria for Accreditation of Undergraduate and Postgraduate Pharmacy Programmes in the ECOWAS Region.”*

Today, meeting at the WAHO Headquarters in Bobo Dioulasso for the *“Workshop to Finalise Curriculum-Based Accreditation Criteria for Undergraduate Pharmacy Training Programmes in the ECOWAS Region”* is a testimony to the progress made. It signals that the draft document is finally nearing acceptance.

We must thank the Director General of WAHO for his vision in ensuring the production of a document that will serve as a Benchmark Minimum Academic Standard (BMAS) for both undergraduate and postgraduate training of pharmacists within universities across the region.

It is also important to acknowledge the dedication and commitment of Professor Kear, whose contributions throughout this process have been invaluable.

The present workshop of November 19–20, 2013, is significant as it provides the opportunity to cross-check, refine, and finalise the details of the work done during previous workshops.

2.0 THE NEED FOR ACCREDITATION

Accreditation of pharmacy programmes in the ECOWAS region is essential to ensure that standards are maintained and sustained. Integrity in the accreditation process is critical for all pharmacy degree programmes, whether at the undergraduate or postgraduate level.

A country or region must deliberately work towards producing the calibre of manpower it desires, and accreditation is one of the key tools for achieving this. In other words, the quality of accreditation of pharmacy programmes in our

universities directly impacts the quality of pharmacy practice in our countries. Thus, pharmacy education and pharmacy practice are inseparably intertwined.

The various regulatory agencies within the ECOWAS region—such as the Pharmacists Council of Nigeria (PCN), the Pharmacy Council of Ghana (PCG), among others—were established primarily to regulate and control pharmacy education and practice in all its dimensions.

In Nigeria, for example, the PCN drafts the BMAS for the undergraduate pharmacy curriculum, secures its approval at the level of its Governing Council, and forwards it to the National Universities Commission (NUC), which regulates university programmes nationwide.

In practice, two accreditation teams usually visit universities offering pharmacy programmes:

- The PCN team, which focuses more on professional practice components, and
- The NUC team, which emphasises the academic aspects.

For a pharmacy programme to be recognised, the university must be successfully accredited by both PCN and NUC. Only then can students graduate, be inducted, and take the pharmacist's oath, allowing them to commence their mandatory one-year internship training under the supervision of a registered and licensed pharmacist. This internship is conducted in centres inspected and accredited by the PCN.

3.0 THE NEED FOR MINIMUM STANDARDS OF PRACTICE

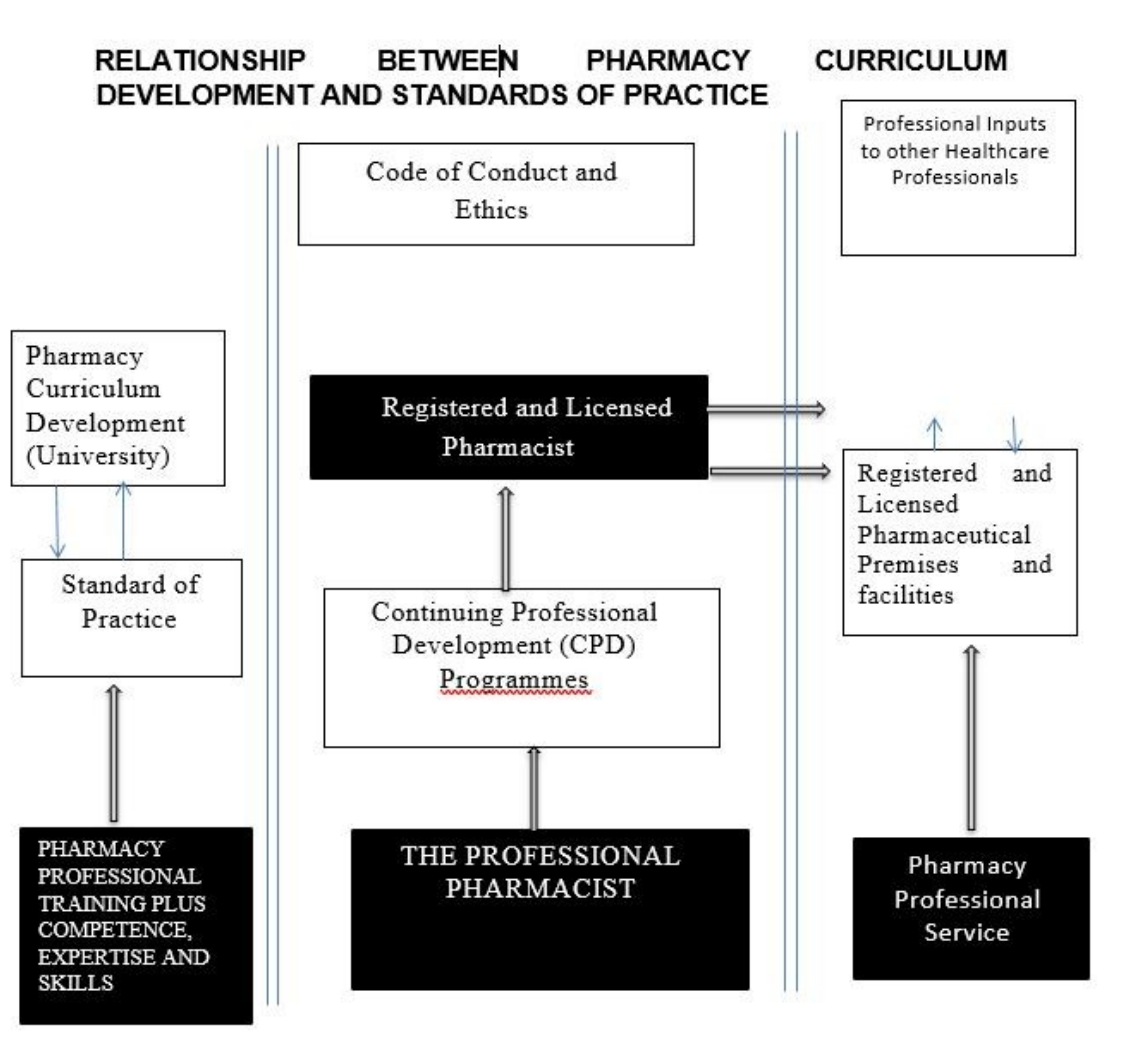
As earlier highlighted, accreditation must align with the level of pharmacy practice intended within a country or across the region. This makes it necessary to develop minimum standards of practice, which define benchmarks below which no pharmacy institution—whether retail pharmacy, hospital pharmacy, wholesaler, distributor, importer of pharmaceutical products, or manufacturer—should fall.

Each country must define its minimum standards in alignment with the BMAS for undergraduate pharmacy curricula.

In Nigeria, the PCN addressed this need by publishing in 2005 the “Four-Part Compendium of Minimum Standards for the Assurance of Pharmaceutical Care in Nigeria.” This landmark document, the first of its kind in Nigeria’s pharmacy regulatory history, provided practitioners with clear benchmarks across the four main areas of practice.

PCN-appointed pharmaceutical inspectors have since relied on this compendium as a reference tool during inspections of pharmaceutical premises, both for relicensing and for approval of new facilities.

Table 1: Relationship Between Accreditation Criteria (BMAS) and Minimum Standards of Practice (Compendium)



CONCLUSION

In conclusion, it is our hope that during these two days of deliberations we will be able to finalise the draft document and set the stage for its adoption across the ECOWAS region.

Thank you for your kind attention.

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